



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON 4.2 : UNLOCKING THE NATURAL MINOR SCALE

Introduction: Understanding the Natural Minor Scale

The natural minor scale is a versatile and expressive scale that's essential for guitarists in many genres, including rock, blues, metal, and jazz. Known for its darker, melancholic sound compared to the major scale, the natural minor scale is commonly used for creating solos, building minor chord progressions, and composing melodies that evoke an emotional response.

In this lesson, we'll explore the structure of the natural minor scale, how it differs from the major scale, and how to play it across the fretboard. We'll also discuss its relationship to chords and its applications in music to help you unlock its full potential.

What is the Natural Minor Scale?

The natural minor scale is a seven-note scale that has a specific pattern of tones and semitones. It is the relative minor of its corresponding major scale, meaning it shares the same notes but starts from a different root note.

Natural Minor Scale Formula:

The interval pattern for the natural minor scale is:

- **Tone, Semitone, Tone, Tone, Semitone, Tone, Tone**

This interval sequence gives the natural minor scale its distinct sound, which is more somber and less resolved than the major scale. Let's break it down using the A natural minor scale as an example:

A Natural Minor Scale Notes:

A - B - C - D - E - F - G - A (octave)

Interval Pattern:

Tone - Semitone - Tone - Tone - Semitone - Tone - Tone

- A to B: Tone
- B to C: Semitone
- C to D: Tone
- D to E: Tone
- E to F: Semitone
- F to G: Tone
- G to A: Tone



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The natural minor scale can be derived by starting from the 6th degree of its relative major scale. In the case of A minor, the relative major scale is C major. This means that A minor and C major share the same notes but have different starting points and tonal centers.

Learning the Natural Minor Scale on Guitar

To master the natural minor scale on the guitar, it's important to learn it in multiple positions and connect these positions across the neck. This approach helps you see the entire fretboard as one cohesive system, making it easier to improvise and create melodic lines.

1. Open Position Natural Minor Scale (Key of A Minor)

Start by playing the A natural minor scale in the open position. Use the following fret and string pattern:

A MINOR SCALE - OPEN POSITION

T													
A													
B	0	2	3	0	2	3	0	2	2	0	3	2	0

A Minor Scale - Open Position

Practice Tip: Say the note names aloud (A, B, C, D, E, F, G, A) as you play. This helps reinforce note recognition and visualization of the scale on the fretboard.

2. Learning the Natural Minor Scale in Five Positions (CAGED System)

The CAGED system divides the natural minor scale into five interlocking patterns that cover the entire fretboard. These positions are named after the open chord shapes: C, A, G, E, and D.

- **Position 1: A Shape (A Minor Scale Root on the A String, 5th Fret)**
- **Position 2: G Shape (Root on the E String, 3rd Fret)**
- **Position 3: E Shape (Root on the E String, 5th Fret)**
- **Position 4: D Shape (Root on the D String, 7th Fret)**
- **Position 5: C Shape (Root on the A String, 12th Fret)**

By learning these positions, you'll gain the ability to play the natural minor scale all over the neck and connect the shapes smoothly.

Practice Tip: Focus on one position at a time. Once comfortable, try moving between adjacent positions.



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3. Practicing the Natural Minor Scale with the 3-Note-Per-String Method

The 3-Note-Per-String method is a highly effective way to practice the natural minor scale on guitar, allowing for increased speed, fluidity, and seamless transitions across the fretboard.

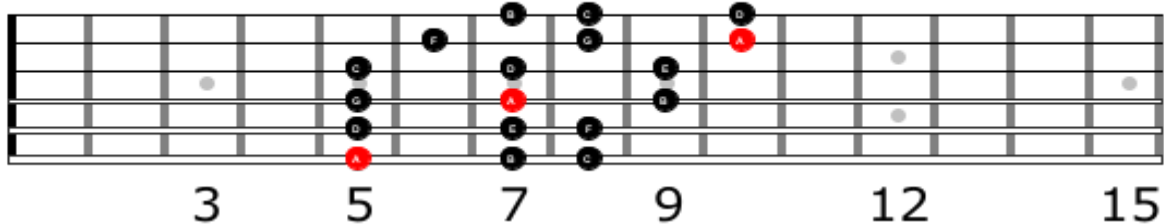
By placing three notes on each string, you create a consistent pattern that encourages linear movement up and down the neck. This method minimizes the need for position shifts and string crossings, making it ideal for legato playing, alternate picking, and creating smooth melodic runs.

Additionally, because the 3-Note-Per-String system covers a wider range horizontally, it provides an expanded view of the fretboard, making it easier to connect different scale positions.

For example, to play the A natural minor scale using the 3-Note-Per-String method, you would begin on the 5th fret of the low E string (A), playing A-B-C with your index, middle, and pinky fingers. Then, you move to the A string and play D-E-F using the same finger sequence.

This pattern continues up the fretboard until you've covered all strings, resulting in a more comprehensive understanding of the scale's layout and a strong foundation for improvisation. Practicing the natural minor scale in this manner helps you break free from boxed patterns and gain the flexibility to traverse the fretboard with confidence and ease.

A Aeolian



3. Connecting the Scale Across the Fretboard

Play the natural minor scale across the entire fretboard by starting in one position and shifting into the next. This helps you visualize the scale patterns as a continuous sequence rather than separate shapes.

Exercise: Play an A natural minor scale starting from the 5th fret (Position 1) and continue through Positions 2, 3, 4, and 5 until you reach the 12th fret (octave).

Understanding the Relationship Between the Natural Minor Scale and Chords

The natural minor scale provides the foundation for constructing minor chords and minor chord progressions. Each note in the natural minor scale corresponds to a degree that can be used to build triads and extended chords.



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Building Triads from the Natural Minor Scale

To build triads from the natural minor scale, select the 1st (root), 3rd, and 5th notes. For example, in the A natural minor scale:

- **A Minor Triad:** A (root), C (minor 3rd), E (5th)
- **B Diminished Triad:** B (root), D (minor 3rd), F (diminished 5th)
- **C Major Triad:** C (root), E (major 3rd), G (5th)

This gives us the diatonic chords in A minor: Am, Bdim, C, Dm, Em, F, and G.

Diatonic Chords in the Natural Minor Scale

Each degree of the natural minor scale creates a specific type of chord. Here's a quick overview of the diatonic chords built from the natural minor scale:

1. **i (Minor)**
2. **ii° (Diminished)**
3. **III (Major)**
4. **iv (Minor)**
5. **v (Minor)**
6. **VI (Major)**
7. **VII (Major)**

For A minor, this gives us:

- **Am (i), Bdim (ii°), C (III), Dm (iv), Em (v), F (VI), and G (VII).**

Using the Natural Minor Scale for Improvisation and Soloing

The natural minor scale is an excellent tool for creating melodic lines and solos with a darker, more introspective sound. To use the natural minor scale effectively in improvisation:

1. **Target Chord Tones:** Emphasize the root, minor 3rd, and 5th notes of each chord in your solo.
2. **Use Passing Tones:** Use the non-chord tones of the natural minor scale as passing notes to add melodic movement.
3. **Add Vibrato and Bends:** Make your solo more expressive by adding vibrato or bending up to important notes (e.g., bending the 4th note to reach the 5th).



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Exercise: Play over an A minor chord progression (Am - Dm - Em - Am) and use the A natural minor scale to create simple melodies. Focus on targeting chord tones and using the entire scale.

Exercises for Unlocking the Natural Minor Scale

Exercise 1: Play the Natural Minor Scale in One Octave

1. Choose a starting note on any string (e.g., A on the 5th fret of the low E string).
2. Play the natural minor scale up and down one octave, saying each note aloud.

Exercise 2: Practice the Natural Minor Scale in Multiple Positions

1. Play the natural minor scale using Position 1 (A shape).
2. Move to Position 2 (G shape), and continue up the neck.
3. Connect each position smoothly, visualizing the entire fretboard.

Exercise 3: Practice the Minor Scale Using the 3 Note Per String Method Across The Fretboard

1. Play the minor scale starting from the lowest A note on 5th fret of the Low E 6th String
A Aeolian in an ascending form (See PDF Tabs)
2. Move to B Locrian and use a descending method, and continue up the neck
3. Practice Slow and intentionally, singing the notes as you play them

Exercise 4: Build Chords from the Natural Minor Scale

1. Choose a root note (e.g., A).
2. Play a minor triad using the 1st, minor 3rd, and 5th notes (A, C, E).
3. Play through the diatonic chords in the key using the natural minor scale.